Irrationalism in Freud:

An Analysis of the Death Instinct

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The rise of psychology in the public consciousness at the turn of the 20th century can be unequivocally attributed to the works of Sigmund Freud. Freud's theory pivoted – and, indeed, found its main force – in a simple thesis: "A dream is a fulfilment of a wish." (S. Freud, 1900). Within this simple premise, psychoanalysis explored the then-revolutionary concept of the unconscious mind — the part of the mind that, unbeknownst to us, holds our deepest desires — which only reveals itself in omissions (dreams, jokes, mistakes, slips of tongue, misrecognitions). These obliquely realised desires grant pleasure to the self, and it is this pleasure that is the motivation for all our thoughts, emotions and behaviour. Psychoanalysis, in denying that people have the agency to fulfil their own desires through the exercise of their free will, thus dismisses both the rationality and the agency of a person.

Freud spent nearly two decades of his life expanding and refining his theory on the basis of this pleasure principle. However, the publication of 'Beyond the Pleasure Principle' (1920) after the First World War marked a significant change in Freudian theory. In this essay, I first aim to provide a measured summary of this pivotal paper; further, I posit that the irrationalism that is inherent to the project of psychoanalysis not only deepens but also becomes irrevocably tied to materialism in the framework of death instincts proposed by Freud in this paper.

Much like the rest of Freud's writing, Parts I–III of 'Beyond the Pleasure Principle' (1920) is densely packed with scientific observations and accompanying hypotheses undercut by personal, narrative storytelling. In the Part I, Freud revises the foundational 'pleasure principle' that his works hinge upon. He clarifies an economical, supply and demand, role of pleasure in the psychoanalytical model: 'excitation' in the mind is increased by pain and decreased by pleasure; the pleasure principle is thus defined by him as "the hypothesis that the mental apparatus endeavours to keep the quantity of excitation in it as low as possible or at least to keep it constant" (S. Freud, 1955, pp. 8–9). The tendency towards an

irrationalism is present in the linguistic structuring of this principle itself: it is the *mental apparatus* that performs the pleasure principle, not the self.

He goes on to assert that the pleasure principle does not dominate mental processes — if this were the case, all experiences would tend towards pleasure; however, we are aware this is not true by virtue of our conscious experiences. The other force within classic psychoanalytical theory that opposes the pleasure principle is the ego's reality principle; however, the reality principle "can only be made responsible for a small number, and by no means the most intense, of unpleasurable experiences" (p. 10). From here, he goes on to list the sources of 'unpleasure', and through this listing he begins to undo the theoretical strength of his own pleasure principle.

First, in cases where the original impulse to pleasure is repressed into the unconsciousness, it becomes a source of unpleasure through its constant conflict with this repression. A second source of unpleasure is perceptual in nature, deriving from external threats of danger—in particular, the 'war neuroses' (or post-traumatic stress disorder, as we now term it) that manifest in traumatic dreams of World War I veterans, which pose a problem for the pleasure principle because "it would be more in harmony with [the] nature [of dreams] if they showed the patient pictures from his healthy past," in lieu of revisiting their trauma (p. 13). The third challenge to the pleasure principle occurs in his witnessing of his grandson's play-enactment, where a toy spool is thrown out of sight, symbolizing the distressing departure of his mother from his care. Fourth, he cites the struggle of patients that, in the transference stage, resist the urge to confront their past, childhood desires and then become "obliged to repeat the repressed material as a contemporary experience" (p. 18).

The problem here is complicated by the underlying compulsion of the self to *repeat* in each of these examples. Repetition cannot be pleasurable because "novelty is always the condition of enjoyment" (p. 35). Active repetition, as in children's toy-play, is a symptom of attempting to "master the stimulus retroactively" (p. 32) that can result in unpleasure; but it is the passive experiences, like the war veteran's dreams, that cause the more serious overriding for the pleasure principle (p. 22). The pleasure principle is

not just defeated, but repetitively and comprehensibly defeated, because these examples constantly "recall past experiences which include no possibility of pleasure and which can never, even long ago, have brought satisfaction…" (p.20). Freud is almost desperate in his writing when he asks: "How then does his repetition of this distressing experience […] fit in with the pleasure principle?" (p. 15).

Freud's attempt to reconcile his pleasure principle with the strong evidence provided by these cases leads him to, very uncharacteristically, eschew all scientific pretence and warn: "What follows is speculation, often far-fetched speculation" (p. 24) in Part IV. He theorises that the material substance of a biological vesicle[1], due to the constant external stimuli it endures, becomes permanently changed; it would even "be killed by the stimulation emanating from these if it were not provided with a protective shield against stimuli. It acquires this shield in this way: its outermost surface ceases to have the structure proper to living matter, becomes to some degree inorganic…" (pp. 26–27). Any traumatic neurosis is, therefore, an "extensive breach being made in [this] protective shield" (p. 31). However, this shield is assaulted from external stimuli as well as internal excitations or, in other words, 'instincts'. In the case of internal excitations, it has no defence, thus when these instincts "produce too great an increase of unpleasure: there is a tendency to treat them as though they were acting not from the inside but from the outside…" (p. 29).

His biography, first and foremost as a medical practioner and biologist, belatedly a psychologist, is obvious in his returns to the physical site of the body for an explanation. It is here that he reverts to a strong, even empathetic materialist position that pushes the already deeply ingrained irrationalism of psychoanalysis to its brink. Freud then makes a significant leap in his texts – not unnoticed by his followers and certainly a contributor to the controversy surrounding this particular text – where he compares the destructive urge of repetition to the tendency of the body to create a shield. He then posits his hypothesis for what would eventually be called Thanatos, or the death instinct: "The instinct is an urge inherent in organic life to restore an earlier state of things which the living entity has been obliged to

[1] Though it is unclear here whether he means a literal or a metaphysical mind.

abandon under the pressure of external disturbing forces" (p. 36). In other words, everything living, organic, has the instinct to go back to its earlier state, that is, become inorganic once again. Freud claims that the implications of this death instinct mean that "we shall be compelled to say that 'the aim of all life is death' and, looking backwards, that 'inanimate things existed before living ones'."(p. 38). These death instincts are more primal than the sexual instincts that follow the pleasure principle. To him, everything is a detour from death, which is the perfect reconciliation. Death instinct is therefore the birth of creation. It is obvious that the self (unconscious or not) is forcefully erased in the death instinct – the problematic materialism that it proposes makes this paper "further noteworthy in being the only one of Freud's which has received little acceptance on the part of his followers" (Jones, 1957).

The irrational thrust of his argument is clear in his concluding section that reads, "the present development of human beings requires, as it seems to me, no different explanation from that of animals" (p. 42). However, Freud's preoccupation with death, marked in 'Beyond the Pleasure Principle' and much of his later writing, has "invited the suggestion that his thinking was colored darkly by the death of his charming and attractive daughter Sophie in January 1920." (Gay, 1995, p. 594). His position may be understood as an overarching pessimism. The turn of his thought is evident in his writing in-between wars, witnessing the destruction of a civilization, ideas of progress, rationality, reason which occurred paradoxically due to the acceleration in science (and accompanying ideas of rationality) and industrialization of death.

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